Send Bulk Mail without Being Treated like a Spammer

There are several ways to send bulk mail that's not treated as spam. The easiest way is to sign up for a service like Mailchimp. However, there is a great thrill in setting up your own bulk mailing infrastructure, which is what this article is about.

Most organisations would like to engage with their customers or the community by sending out regular product updates. As the volume of emails sent grows, over-aggressive filters at the receiving end are likely to flag these emails as 'Spam' and trash them, often without informing the sender of this action. As a consequence of this, the reputation of the organisation's domain may get tarnished, resulting in the domain being listed on one of the several online blacklists like Spamhaus.

To set up your own bulk mailing infrastructure, let's assume that you have access to the command line, ideally on a VPS or dedicated server. I have used a Centos 6.4 VPS, so the commands are for Centos, but Ubuntu users can easily adapt the steps. First, here's an inventory of the things we need.

- A VPS or bare metal machine connected to the Internet
- PHPList
- MySQL
- A registered domain with access to change the DNS zone entries

PHPList

PHPList is a popular open source newsletter manager written in PHP. Let's use this to set up our bulk mailing infrastructure to manage our subscription lists. So get started and download the required files like the PHPlist TGZ from *http://www.phplist.com* into your home directory.

```
$wget http://downloads.sourceforge.net/project/phplist/
phplist/3.0.6/phplist-3.0.6.tgz?r=http%3A%2F%2Fwww.phplist.
com%2Fdownload&ts=1403941429&use_mirror=jaist
```

It's a long URL, so rather than typing it, you can copy the URL from the direct link that appears when you download PHPList from Sourceforge. Alternatively, you can download it to your laptop and then upload it to your server, though I wouldn't recommend it.

Unpack the archive in your HOME folder. This should create a directory called *phplist-3.0.6*. This directory has a sub-directory called *public_html/lists* which contains the files that are required to run PHPList; the rest of the files are not required for PHPList to work. However, we'll let these files remain.

```
$tar -zxvf phplist-3.0.6.tgz
```

MySQL

Now, let's create a database for PHPList. Most Linux distributions have MySQL installed by default. To check if MySQL is installed, type the following in your CLI:

```
$ mysql -V
mysql Ver 14.14 Distrib 5.1.69, for redhat-linux-gnu (i386)
using readline 5.1
```